



JONATHAN YEDDER/Staff

Angie Kornhauser handles Borka, an American Kestrel falcon, during a demonstration of the new Carolina Raptor Center. Hundreds of people attended the grand opening.

A new nest to call home

Carolina Raptor Center dedicates 4,000-square-foot facility

By RHONDA Y. WILLIAMS
Staff Writer

Hundreds of people gazed anxiously at the red-tailed hawk. Just five months ago, the immature bird was found on Hilton Head Island — his leg broken.

Sunday, that hawk faced the ultimate test of recovery.

In a small dirt clearing behind the Carolina Raptor Center in Charlotte, a man tossed the hawk skyward. And off it flew, its 4-foot-wide wings gracefully disappearing through the trees.

The crowd cheered, pointed, clapped and snapped cameras. For the raptor center, the hawk's successful release was just one more thing to celebrate Sunday.

"I like to be up close and look at the birds. I love those big eyes on the owls. They just melt your heart."

— Rosie Little

Minutes before, they dedicated the new 4,000-square-foot facility featuring an aviary, exhibit hall, classrooms and library. And they sold personalized bricks at \$35 a piece to raise money to manage and feed the prey.

For 10 years, volunteers worked out of two mobile trailers on the

57-acre site, nursing birds back to health and then releasing them.

In an opening prayer, board member Jim Arthur, who led the charge for the new center, said, "Our heavenly father, on this perfectly beautiful day, we thank you for this building ... and the trust you have given us for the stewardship of nature."

Edna Moretti, the building's namesake, then used huge scissors to cut the blue ribbon. It was her husband, Fred Moretti, who set the red-tailed hawk free.

Afterward, visitors strolled along the center's half-mile nature trail. There, 20 species of birds live.

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Raptor

Bird lovers help center celebrate

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There are the barn owls (Tyto Alba). A sign hangs on their aviary: "Shhhhhhh. We're making BABIES!"

There's Honeysuckle, the partial albino red-tailed hawk (*Buteo Jamaicensis*). A placard explains she becomes whiter each year she molts her feathers.

And there's a bald eagle (*Haliaeetus Leucocephalus*), who only has one wing.

"I like seeing the birds," said Andrew Robertson, 9, of Mooresville.

The Little family drove from Gastonia.

"I especially like the owls," said Scott Little, 13. "The way they can turn their heads and move their eyes."

Mom, Rosie Little, loves the owls too.

"I like to be up close and look at the birds," she said. "I love those big eyes on the owls. They just melt your heart."

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